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Gubernatorial Candidate's Antisemitic Statement in California Voter Guide Draws Backlash from Jewish Community

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A gubernatorial candidate's statement in California's official voter information guide is drawing criticism for including antisemitic conspiracy claims unrelated to his background or qualifications.

The statement, submitted by Don J. Grundmann, appears in the voter guide published by the California Secretary of State for the June 2, 2026 primary election.

The guides were mailed to voters across the state the week of April 20.

Grundmann, who lists no qualified party preference, is one of 32 candidates included in the guide. He is the only candidate without a submitted photograph in the online listing.

In his statement, Grundmann claims that "Israel 'art students' wired Twin Towers for 9/11 controlled demolition" and that "planes did NOT destroy [sic] towers. Israel did." He also writes that Israel is "our greatest enemy, NOT Iran," and alleges that Israel "created and funds Hamas via Qatar."

Additional statements in the submission include: "No further funding for Israel. They call Palestinians AND Christians AND America 'Amalek' — their sworn forever enemy. We are 'goyim' (less than human animals/cattle) that they will enslave. We are stupid chumps. Israel rules our conquered Republic."

The claims echo long-debunked conspiracy theories and are not tied to his personal background or qualifications.

California's published guidelines for candidate statements state that submissions "should be limited to a recitation of the candidate's own personal background and qualifications" and may not reference opponents. The statements are submitted by candidates and are not fact-checked by the state. The voter guide includes a disclaimer noting that the views expressed are those of the candidates and not the Secretary of State's office.

Members of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus also condemned the inclusion of the statement and said they are exploring legislative responses. They urged California Secretary of State Shirley Weber to issue a public apology and remove the statement from the voter guide website.

"We were outraged to learn that the Official Voter Information Guide for the California Primary — prepared by the Secretary of State and mailed to more than 23 million California voters — includes antisemitic conspiracy theories and links to websites with horrific racism, homophobia, and misogyny," Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), chair of the Jewish Caucus said. "This is dangerous, deeply offensive, and antithetical to California's proud tradition of standing up to hate. We profoundly disagree with the decision to include this hate speech in the Voter Guide and are already working on legislation to address this issue."

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Assemblymember Gail Pellerin (D-Santa Cruz), also a member of the Jewish Caucus condemned the statements.

"During my 27 years as a county elections official, I rejected numerous candidate statements that failed to comply with the Elections Code's requirement that they be limited to a recitation of a candidate's background and

qualifications," Pellerin said. "The antisemitic statement included in the state voter information guide is reprehensible. It does not reflect California's values and has no place in voter resources produced and distributed by the state. I will work with my colleagues to advance legislation that ensures that this kind of content never appears in official election materials again."

The caucus said it has been in contact with the office of Governor Gavin Newsom and is considering next steps, including potential legislation.

Calls and emails from the Journal to Secretary of State Shirley Weber's office were not returned.

Members of Los Angeles' Jewish community have expressed outrage.

"This is beyond anything you can imagine, using taxpayer's money to tell millions of voters: Israel is behind 9/11 and more," Prof. Judea Pearl told The Journal. "The only way for the State to undo this idiotic fumble is to send a revised Voter Guide, telling voters (at equal length) what Israel's contributions to humanity have been, despite 78 years of unending harassment by her neighbors." Advocacy group StandWithUs called on state officials to remove the statement, arguing it violates California's guidelines by promoting "hateful rhetoric and conspiracy theories unrelated to his background or qualifications."

Under California law, candidates may purchase space in the voter guide to publish a statement of up to 250 words. For statewide offices such as governor, voluntary spending limits tied to these statements reach into the tens of millions of dollars.

Grundmann has repeatedly run for statewide office in California, primarily for U.S. Senate, over more than a decade.

Records show Grundmann has run for U.S. Senate in at least six election cycles since 2010. In each race, he received fewer than 500 votes, including 123 votes in the 2024 presidential primary, 168 votes in the 2022 primary and 239 votes in the 2018 primary. Earlier races include 243 votes in 2016, 481 votes in 2012 and 273 votes in 2010, according to election records .

Those primary campaigns placed him in large candidate fields, often called a "nonpartisan primary" or a "jungle primary" with more than two dozen opponents. The top two candidates move on to the general election. Weber wrote about misinformation in elections in a 2025 LA Times Op-Ed about the Safeguard American Voter Eligibility Act (SAVE Act) being considered by the U.S. House of Representatives,

"Americans must not be fooled by fearmongering and misleading rhetoric," Weber wrote.

On April 27, the Secretary of State's office wrote on twitter, "If you see a post that is inaccurate or misleading, report it by emailing VoteSure@sos.ca.gov"

It remains unclear whether state officials plan to take action specifically regarding Grundmann's statement.

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